FREE GUIDE · FIRST OFFER ACADEMY

The First Offer Playbook

How to Land Your First Internship Before Junior Year

Everything in here is free. It's the exact system I used through the two most recent recruiting cycles, and the one I've taught to freshmen. The tactics aren't the hard part. Doing them every week is.

16 chapters, every template included

The resume rubric, the target list, the AI outreach system, 5 cold email templates, the call framework, the referral close, the story map, technicals by track, and an 8-week calendar to 500 emails.

First Offer Academy

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CHAPTER 1

How recruiting actually works

The 5 things that matter, ranked, and the market students starting recruiting can actually win.

Here's the thing nobody tells you as a freshman: recruiting doesn't reward the smartest student. It rewards the most persistent one. The student who sent the 40th email, followed up on time, and practiced their stories out loud will beat the student with the better GPA who waited to be discovered.

Most students study for recruiting in reverse order. They start with technicals because that feels like school, then they polish the resume, and networking comes last, if at all. The actual order of importance is the opposite.

The 5 things that matter, ranked

#	WHAT	WHY IT'S RANKED HERE
1	Networking	Most early internships are filled by someone who already knows you, or knows someone who does. A resume gets read because a person asked to see it.
2	Resume	It's the document every conversation ends up at. It doesn't need to be impressive; it needs to be clean, specific, and easy to talk through.
3	Enthusiasm	Interviewers hire people they want to sit next to for ten weeks. Real interest in the work, backed by specifics, beats a perfect answer.
4	Behaviorals	"Tell me about a time..." questions decide more first rounds than technicals do, especially for students starting recruiting.
5	Technicals	They matter, and you'll learn them. But for students starting recruiting, nobody expects you to know everything. They expect you to be learning.

Why clubs matter less than people think

Clubs are useful. They give you reps, mock interviews, and a group chat of people going through the same thing. But a club is one way to get those things, not a gate you have to pass. If you didn't get in, you haven't lost anything you can't build yourself: a resume that passes a rubric, a target list, an outreach system, and a stack of calls.

The freshman and sophomore market

The famous firms with the famous programs are a small slice of the market, and they're where everyone applies. The rest of the market is bigger, quieter, and much more open to a student starting recruiting who shows up prepared:

- Boutiques: Small, specialized firms (advisory, investment, accounting, agencies). Fewer applicants, and a single conversation can turn into an interview.
- Middle-market firms: Firms that work with mid-sized companies. Real work, lean teams, and more willingness to take an intern who's just starting out.
- Local firms near you: Wealth managers, accounting and advisory firms, family offices, agencies, and operating companies. Being local is an advantage you should use.
- Startups: They hire for hustle and learn-fast. Founders often answer cold emails themselves.
- Early-insight and diversity programs: Structured programs at larger firms built for students early in college. Deadlines are early and dates change every year, so check each one directly.

From Tyler

Networking is ranked first for a reason. Early opportunities rarely start in an application portal. They start with someone who replied to an email and remembered the call.

Chapter 1 checklist

- [ ] Write down the 5 things in order, and how many hours a week you currently spend on each.
- [ ] List three firms you'd never heard of until you read the market list above.
- [ ] Decide how many hours a week you can honestly commit for the next 8 weeks.

CHAPTER 2

The recruiting calendar by track and by quarter

What to do in each quarter from freshman fall to junior year, across Finance and Accounting, plus Marketing and Tech.

The most common thing I hear from sophomores is some version of "I didn't know it started this early." For finance and accounting especially, many of the processes that decide junior summer open during sophomore year. The students who do well started building in freshman year: not by applying everywhere, but by doing a few boring things consistently.

Recruiting calendar by field

FIELD	FRESHMAN YEAR	SOPHOMORE YEAR	JUNIOR YEAR
Finance (banking, investing)	Resume, target list, first calls. Apply to early-insight and diversity programs.	Heavy networking in fall and winter. Many junior-summer processes open during sophomore year. Sophomore internships at boutiques and local firms.	Junior-summer internship (the one that most often leads to a full-time offer). Remaining processes run early in the year.
Marketing	Portfolio pieces, a campus or local role, calls with marketers at brands and agencies.	Internships at agencies, startups, and brands. Many postings go up in winter and spring.	Brand and agency internships. Rolling timelines: apply as roles post, and keep a warm list ready.
Accounting	Resume, target list, firm recruiting events and office visits. Apply to early-identification and leadership programs where they exist.	Many early-identification programs run in sophomore year and feed junior-summer internships. Plan coursework toward the CPA's 150-credit-hour requirement.	Junior-summer internship in audit, tax, or advisory: the main path to a full-time offer.
Tech (software, data, product)	One real project, coding practice, freshman programs where they exist.	Many roles post in late summer and fall for the next summer. Referrals matter a lot.	Junior-summer internships, mostly recruited in the fall. Online assessments plus technical interviews.

Freshman through junior year, by quarter

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Freshman fall	Resume v1 (high school counts) · Answer the 25 self-questions · Pick one or two directions · Record your 60-second intro
Freshman winter	Target list of 50 with named contacts · Set up your outreach system · Send 50 sequenced emails a week · First calls
Freshman spring	Turn calls into intros · Write and record 8 stories · Apply to open roles on your list · An externship or a real project
Freshman summer	An internship, a job, or a project you can talk about · Keep 10–15 relationships warm · Start technicals for your track
Sophomore year	Recruiting for sophomore internships and early junior-summer processes · Mocks, technicals, and the 6-month game plan on repeat
Junior year	Junior-summer internship processes (timing depends on track) · Use every relationship you've kept warm

Dates move

Timelines move earlier almost every year and differ by firm. Treat this as a planning map, and confirm each firm's real dates on its careers page. Put every deadline you find in your 6-month game plan (Chapter 15).

Chapter 2 checklist

- [ ] Circle your track (or your top two).
- [ ] Find the careers page for five firms on your list and write down when their programs open.
- [ ] Put your next three deadlines on your calendar today.

CHAPTER 3

The top-tier resume

The rubric, line-by-line bullet rewrites, and a before-and-after example.

Your resume doesn't need to be impressive. It needs to be clean, specific, and easy to talk about. Every line on it is a question someone might ask you, so every line should be something you'd enjoy answering.

Here's the rubric we grade every resume against. A resume passes when every box is checked.

Format

- [ ] One page. No exceptions for students starting recruiting.
- [ ] One clean, standard font; 10–12 pt body; margins no smaller than 0.5 in.
- [ ] No photos, graphics, color blocks, skill bars, or two-column templates.
- [ ] Consistent dates, punctuation, and alignment on every line.
- [ ] Saved as a PDF named Firstname-Lastname-Resume.pdf.

Header

- [ ] Name, phone, school email, city, and LinkedIn URL. Nothing else.
- [ ] LinkedIn URL is customized (no random numbers) and the profile matches the resume.

Education

- [ ] School, degree, major, expected graduation month and year.
- [ ] GPA listed if it's 3.5 or higher; otherwise leave it off and be ready to answer if asked.
- [ ] Relevant coursework only if it's specific to the field (no "Intro to College Writing").
- [ ] High school listed in freshman year, with real achievements; drop it by junior year.

Experience bullets

- [ ] Every bullet starts with a strong past-tense verb (present tense only for current roles).
- [ ] Every bullet shows an outcome, not a duty: what changed because you were there.
- [ ] At least half the bullets have a number: people, dollars, hours, percent, count.
- [ ] Each bullet fits on one or two lines. No bullet you couldn't explain for two minutes.
- [ ] No filler phrases: "responsible for," "helped with," "various," "assisted in."

Leadership & activities

- [ ] Real roles with real bullets, not a list of club names.
- [ ] Jobs count: retail, food service, tutoring, family business. They show reliability.
- [ ] Projects count when they have a result (a model built, a site launched, an event run).

Skills & interests

- [ ] Only skills you can use in an interview tomorrow (Excel, SQL, Python, Figma, languages with level).
- [ ] Two or three specific interests that start conversations ("long-distance running," not "sports").

The 6-second test

- [ ] A stranger can tell what you're interested in within six seconds.
- [ ] The strongest item is in the top third of the page.
- [ ] Zero typos. Read it backwards, then have someone else read it.

Bullets are outcomes, not duties

The fastest way to improve a resume is to rewrite every bullet from what you were responsible for into what changed because you were there. Verb, what you did, result, with a number wherever you can find one.

Bullet rewrites (made-up examples)

BEFORE (A DUTY)	AFTER (AN OUTCOME)
Responsible for social media for the club.	Grew club Instagram from 300 to 1,100 followers in one quarter by posting three times a week and running a member-spotlight series.
Helped with events.	Planned a 120-person networking night with 6 alumni speakers; handled outreach, budget ($900), and day-of logistics.
Worked as a cashier.	Handled 150+ transactions per shift and trained 4 new hires on the register and closing procedures.
Tutored students in math.	Tutored 8 high school students weekly in algebra and pre-calc; 6 of 8 raised their course grade by at least one letter.

Before and after

EXAMPLE ONLY. JORDAN RIVERA IS A MADE-UP STUDENT. NUMBERS ARE ILLUSTRATIVE.

Before: Education: Example State University, Business, 2029 / Experience: Cashier at Example Coffee Co. Responsible for the register and helping customers. / Activities: Member of the business club. Helped with events. / Skills: Microsoft Office, teamwork, communication, leadership

- After: EDUCATION — Example State University, B.A. Business Economics, expected June 2029 · GPA 3.6
- After: EXPERIENCE — Example Coffee Co., Shift Lead (2024–present): Handled 150+ transactions per shift; trained 4 new hires on register and closing; cut end-of-night cash discrepancies to zero over three months by adding a two-person count.
- After: LEADERSHIP — Business Club, Events Committee: Planned a 120-person alumni networking night with 6 speakers; ran outreach and a $900 budget.
- After: PROJECTS — Personal valuation of a consumer company (Excel, comparable companies); presented to a 20-person investing club.
- After: SKILLS — Excel (VLOOKUP, pivot tables), Canva · Spanish (fluent) · Interests: long-distance running, local food trucks

Your 60-second intro

Your resume and your intro are the same story told two ways. Once the resume passes, write the intro: where you're from, what pulled you in, what you've done, and why you're talking to this person. Record it. Watch it. Cut it.

The 60-second intro

PART	TIME	EXAMPLE (MADE-UP)
Where you're from	10 sec	My parents run a small restaurant, so I've done the books on weekends since I was 14.
What pulled you in	15 sec	That's what got me curious about how businesses actually make money.
What you've done	25 sec	At school I've led events for the business club and started teaching myself valuation in Excel.

PART	TIME	EXAMPLE (MADE-UP)
Why you're talking to them	10 sec	I'm reaching out because you went from our school into advisory, and I'd love to understand how you made that jump.

Chapter 3 checklist

- [ ] Grade your resume against every box in the rubric.
- [ ] Rewrite every bullet that starts with "responsible for" or "helped."
- [ ] Add a number to at least half your bullets.
- [ ] Record your 60-second intro, then cut it until it fits.

CHAPTER 4

Building a target list of 50 with contacts

A/B/C tiers, where to find the right people, and what counts as a contact.

A target list is 50 companies, each with a named person you're going to email. Not 50 companies you might apply to someday: 50 names you'll actually contact. Without names, it's a wish list.

The A/B/C target list

TIER	WHAT	HOW MANY (OF 50)	WHY
A	Dream firms	About 10	For relationships, not for this season's offer. You're playing the long game here: calls, updates, and staying warm into sophomore and junior year.
B	Realistic	About 30	Boutiques, middle-market firms, local firms, and startups. This is where most early internships actually come from.
C	Safe	About 10	Places very likely to take a freshman: local businesses, campus roles, small startups, family-network companies. Reps and a line on the resume.

Most of your freshman opportunities will come from your B tier. Your A tier is for relationships that pay off in sophomore and junior year. Your C tier gives you reps and a line on the resume.

Finding the right contacts

1. Start with the firm, not the person: what does it do, how big is it, does it hire interns (even informally)?
2. Find 2–3 people per firm on LinkedIn: same school first, then shared background, then anyone in the role you want.
3. Use a contact tool like Apollo or RecruitEm to find a work email. Verify the format with a second source if you can.
4. Log the named contact, their title, the email, and one personal detail you can use in the first line.
5. No generic inboxes (info@, careers@). A named person or it doesn't count toward the 50.

From Tyler

Alumni from your school reply more than anyone else. Start there. After that, look for anything you share: hometown, high school, first job, first-gen path. People help people who remind them of themselves.

Chapter 4 checklist

- [ ] 50 companies, tiered A/B/C (roughly 10/30/10).
- [ ] A named contact at every company, with an email.
- [ ] One personal detail per contact for your first line.
- [ ] Download the target list template and put it all in one sheet.

CHAPTER 5

The AI outreach system

Personalization prompts, sequencing, the follow-up cadence, and the guardrails.

Sending 50 personalized emails a week sounds impossible until you have a system. Here's the system: AI helps you research and draft, a sequencing tool sends and follows up, and you personalize and read every single email before it goes.

Setting up your sequence

1. Pick a mail-merge or sequencing tool that works with your school email (many students use a Gmail or Outlook add-on).
2. Build your sheet: one row per named contact, columns for first name, firm, subject line, and the personalized first line.
3. Write your base template with merge fields ({{first_name}}, {{firm}}, {{first_line}}).
4. Load the follow-up steps now, not later: up to 4, spaced by the cadence for the season.
5. Set the follow-ups to stop automatically when someone replies.
6. Send a test to yourself. Read every merged email before the real send.
7. Log every reply in the tracker the same day.

The prompts

Paste in real material: their profile, their post, their firm's page. Never just a name. These prompts are built to find specifics and invent nothing.

1. Research the person

Here is a LinkedIn profile and a recent post from someone I want to email: [paste]. List (a) three specific, verifiable things about their career or work, (b) anything we have in common given that I'm a [year] at [school] from [hometown] studying [major], and (c) one thoughtful question I could ask them on a call. Do not invent anything that isn't in the text.

2. Draft the personalized first line

Using only these facts about [name]: [paste facts], write five different first lines for a cold email from a college freshman. Each under 25 words, specific, not flattering, and about them rather than me. Use the 'compliment + connection' idea: one genuine compliment and one real thing we share.

3. Tighten the email

Cut this email to under 120 words without losing the specific first line or the single ask for a short call. Keep it warm and plain; remove any phrase that sounds like a cover letter: [paste draft].

4. Subject lines

Write eight subject lines for this email, each under 8 words. Mix: school connection, their specific work, and a plain question. No clickbait, no exclamation points: [paste email].

Three more prompts (mail-merge personalization, call prep, and the thank-you draft) are in the free AI personalization prompt pack.

The follow-up cadence

At most 4 follow-ups. Weekly in November and December (peak season); biweekly to monthly off-peak.

Follow-up sequence

STEP	PEAK (NOV–DEC)	OFF-PEAK	WHAT TO SEND
Follow-up 1	Day 7	Day 14	Hi [First name], just bumping this up in case it got buried. Would love 20 minutes whenever works. Thank you!
Follow-up 2	Day 14	Day 28	Hi [First name], I know this time of year is busy. I'm still very interested in hearing about your path at [firm]. Even a short call would help a lot.
Follow-up 3	Day 21	Day 45	Hi [First name], I've been [one real update: reading about X / started Y]. It made me want to ask you about [specific question] even more. Any chance for a quick call?
Follow-up 4 (last)	Day 28	Day 75	Hi [First name], I'll leave it here so I'm not crowding your inbox. If a call ever makes sense down the road, I'd be grateful. Thanks for reading.

AI guardrails

- [ ] AI drafts, humans personalize. The first line is always yours.
- [ ] Never send an email you haven't read, start to finish.
- [ ] Never let AI invent a fact about the person. If you can't verify it, cut it.
- [ ] Paste in real material (their profile, their post), not just their name.
- [ ] If the email sounds like a press release, rewrite it the way you'd text a cousin's friend. Politely.

The tracker rule

Only track people who reply. Everyone else lives in your sequence until they do. A tracker full of non-replies hides the relationships that matter.

Chapter 5 checklist

- [ ] Sequencing tool connected to your school email.
- [ ] Sheet built with a personalized first line for every contact.
- [ ] Follow-up steps loaded (up to 4) and set to stop on reply.
- [ ] Test email sent to yourself and read end to end.
- [ ] First 50 sent.

CHAPTER 6

Cold email that gets answered

The Two C's, subject lines, and 5 templates.

A good cold email is short, specific, and about them. The goal is one thing: a short call. The target is a reply rate moving toward 10%. If you're well under that, the problem is almost always the first line, the ask, or the list.

The Two C's

Every email I send has two things in it: a compliment and a connection. People help people who remind them of themselves.

- Compliment: Something specific about them or their work: a deal, a post, a talk, a career move. Specific, not flattering. "I read your post on..." beats "I admire your career."
- Connection: Something you share: same school, same hometown, same first job, same weird path. If you can't find one, the compliment has to carry the email.

Before you hit send

- [ ] Under 120 words. If it takes more than 30 seconds to read, cut it.
- [ ] One ask: a short call. Not a job, not a referral, not "any advice you have."
- [ ] First line is about them, not you.
- [ ] Send from your school email, Tuesday to Thursday morning, their time zone.
- [ ] AI drafts; you personalize. Never send an email you haven't read.

Subject lines

- [School] freshman: quick question about your path into [field]
- Fellow [school] student with a question about [firm]
- Your post on [topic]
- From [hometown] to [role]: a question
- [Mutual contact] suggested I reach out
- Question about the [team] at [firm]

5 templates

Every bracket gets replaced with something real. If you can't fill a bracket with a specific detail, choose a different template or a different person.

1. Same school. Alumni from your school. Your highest reply rate, so start here.

Subject: [School] freshman: quick question about your path into [field]

Hi [First name],

I saw you went from [school] to [firm], and your move from [previous role] into [current role] caught my eye. [One specific detail from their profile or work.]

I'm a freshman studying [major] and trying to learn how people actually break into [field]. Would you be open to a short call in the next couple of weeks? Happy to work around your schedule.

Thank you,
[Your name]
[School] · [LinkedIn URL]

2. Shared background. Same hometown, same high school, same first job, same first-gen path.

Subject: From [hometown] to [role]: a question

Hi [First name],

I noticed you're also from [hometown] (I went to [high school]). Seeing someone from home working in [field] at [firm] made me want to reach out.

I'm a freshman at [school] exploring [field]. Would you have 20 minutes for a quick call sometime soon? I'd love to hear how you got started.

Best,
[Your name]
[LinkedIn URL]

3. Something they made. They wrote a post, gave a talk, were quoted, or worked on something public.

Subject: Your post on [topic]

Hi [First name],

I read your post on [topic], especially the point about [specific point]. It changed how I think about [related idea].

I'm a freshman at [school] interested in [field], and I'd love to ask you a couple of questions about your work at [firm]. Would you be open to a short call in the next two weeks?

Thanks,
[Your name]
[LinkedIn URL]

4. Local or small firm. Local firms, boutiques, and small teams where a student reaching out is rare.

Subject: Local student with a question about [firm]

Hi [First name],

I'm a freshman at [school] and I've been reading about [firm]'s work with [type of client / recent project]. It's rare to find a firm doing [specific thing] right here in [your area].

I'm trying to learn how people get started in [field]. Would you be open to a quick call? I'm local and happy to meet for coffee if that's easier.

Thank you,
[Your name]
[LinkedIn URL]

5. Startup founder. Founders and early employees. Shorter, more direct, lead with what you noticed.

Subject: [Company]'s [feature / launch]

Hi [First name],

I've been using / following [company] since [specific thing], and [one sentence on what impressed you].

I'm a freshman at [school] who wants to learn how early-stage companies work. Would you be open to a 15–20 minute call? If there's ever a small project I could help with, I'd love to hear about it too.

[Your name]
[LinkedIn URL]

Chapter 6 checklist

- [ ] Every email has a compliment and a connection.
- [ ] Under 120 words, one ask.
- [ ] Subject line tested (have a friend pick between two).
- [ ] Reply rate calculated for last week: replies ÷ emails sent.

CHAPTER 7

The call

The full framework, a question bank, and the thank-you.

A reply is not the win. The call is. And the call is where most students lose it, because they treat it like an interview: stiff, prepared, and forgettable. The biggest failure mode is being dry.

From Tyler

I open every call with "Anything exciting going on lately?" When they ask it back, I answer long and casually. It sets the tone: we're two people talking, not an interview. Then I move to my intro and their story, and I listen 80% of the time.

The call, minute by minute (20 minutes)

STAGE	TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
Open	0–3 min	Ask "Anything exciting going on lately?" Then answer it yourself when they ask back: long and casual. You're setting the tone: this is a conversation, not an interview.
Your intro	3–5 min	Your 60-second intro, loosened up. Where you're from, what pulled you in, what you've done, why them.
Their story	5–15 min	How they got here, what they actually do day to day, what they'd do differently. 80% listening, 20% talking.
Questions that prove you listened	15–18 min	Follow-ups on what they just said beat anything you prepared. "You mentioned X. What did that look like?"
The close	18–20 min	"Is there anyone on the team you'd be comfortable introducing me to?" or "Is there another perspective you think would be good for me to hear?" Then thank them and end on time.

Quick prep, with AI

Before every call: what the firm does in two lines, three recent things worth asking about, and one question about their personal path. Use the call-prep prompt from the free AI prompt pack, then check every fact yourself.

Question bank

Their path

- [ ] How did you end up in [field]? Was it the plan?
- [ ] What did you do in college that actually mattered for getting here?
- [ ] If you were a freshman again, what would you do differently?
- [ ] What surprised you most in your first few months on the job?

The work

- [ ] What does a normal week look like for you?
- [ ] What part of the job do you enjoy most on a bad day?
- [ ] What separates the interns who get asked back?
- [ ] What skill do you wish you'd built earlier?

The firm

- [ ] What makes [firm] different from similar firms you considered?
- [ ] How does the team work together day to day?
- [ ] What's the firm focused on this year?
- [ ] Does the team ever take interns early in college, formally or informally?

Advice

- [ ] Where would you focus if you were in my position this year?
- [ ] Is there anything on my resume you'd change?
- [ ] What should I read or learn before I talk to more people in [field]?

The thank-you

Thank-you email (send 1–2 hours after the call)

Subject: Thank you, [First name]

Hi [First name],

Thank you for the call today. [Specific thing they said] really stuck with me, and I'm going to [specific action you'll take because of it].

I'll [next step you promised, e.g. "reach out to Sam as you suggested"] and let you know how it goes.

Thanks again,
[Your name]

Chapter 7 checklist

- [ ] Prepped the firm and the person.
- [ ] Opened with "anything exciting lately?"
- [ ] Listened 80% of the time.
- [ ] Used the close (Chapter 8).
- [ ] Sent the thank-you within 2 hours and logged it in the tracker.

CHAPTER 8

Turning calls into referrals

The close, staying warm, and the tracker.

Calls are how you meet people. Referrals and introductions are how you get in the door. You get there without ever asking for one directly.

The rule

Never ask for a referral directly. Asking puts people on the spot; offering them an easy way to help doesn't.

- "Is there anyone on the team you'd be comfortable introducing me to?"
- "Is there another perspective you think would be good for me to hear?"

If they say no: "Totally understand, thank you for the time today." Then send the thank-you anyway. A "no" today is usually about timing, not about you.

If they say yes: Thank them, offer to send a two-line blurb they can forward, and follow up within 24 hours if the intro hasn't happened.

Forwardable blurb

Hi [First name], thank you again for offering to connect me with [Name]. Here's a short note you can forward if it helps:

> "[Your name] is a freshman at [school] interested in [field]. We talked about [topic] and I think a conversation with you would be useful for them."

Staying warm for months

Most relationships die from silence, not from rejection. A short, specific note every few weeks keeps you in someone's head when a role opens.

Staying warm

WHEN	WHAT
Within 2 hours	Thank-you email with one specific detail.
When you act on their advice	A short update: "You suggested X; I did it and here's what happened."
Every 6–8 weeks	A one-line check-in with something real (a result, an article relevant to their work, a question).
Holidays	A personal note, not a template. One sentence about something they told you.
When recruiting opens	Tell them you're applying and ask one specific question about the process.

Logging every relationship

For every person who replied: when you spoke, what they said, who they introduced you to, and when you're due to follow up. If it's not in the tracker, you'll forget it, and so will they.

Chapter 8 checklist

- [ ] The close used on every call.
- [ ] Forwardable blurb sent within 24 hours of every yes.
- [ ] An update sent to anyone whose advice you acted on.
- [ ] Next follow-up date set for every contact in the tracker.

CHAPTER 9

Behavioral stories

The 25 self-questions, the story template, and mapping 8 stories to 10 questions.

Behavioral questions decide more first rounds for students starting recruiting than technicals do. You need 8 stories, chosen for uniqueness, not impressiveness. The best stories are usually the ones you think are too small.

Step 1: answer the 25 self-questions

Don't write stories yet. Just answer these honestly, in bullet points. This is your raw material.

1. What's something you did that nobody asked you to do?
2. When did you lead something, formally or not?
3. When did you fail at something that mattered to you?
4. What's the hardest feedback you've ever received?
5. When did you disagree with someone and how did it end?
6. What's a job or responsibility you had that most students your age didn't?
7. When did you have to learn something fast?
8. When did a team you were on fall apart, and what did you do?
9. What have you built, started, or organized?
10. When did you change someone's mind?
11. What's the most stressful week you've had, and how did you get through it?
12. When did you make a decision without enough information?
13. What's a mistake you made that affected other people?
14. When did you go beyond what was required?
15. What does your family expect of you, and how has that shaped you?
16. What's something you're known for among friends?
17. When did you help someone who was struggling?
18. What's a goal you set and hit? One you set and missed?
19. When did you have to work with someone you didn't like?
20. What's the most interesting problem you've ever worked on?
21. When did you take a risk?
22. What would people be surprised to learn about you?
23. What made you interested in this field in the first place?
24. When did you notice something others missed?
25. What are you proudest of that isn't on your resume?

Step 2: pick 8 and write them

The story template

PART	WHAT TO WRITE
Situation	Where were you, what was at stake, and why did it matter? Two sentences.
What you did	The specific actions you took. Use "I," not "we." This is most of the story.
What changed	The result, with a number if you have one. What was different because you acted?
What you learned	One sentence you'd actually say to a friend, and how you've used it since.

Step 3: map them

These 10 questions (and their variations) cover most behavioral interviews:

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. Tell me about a time you led a team.
3. Tell me about a time you failed.
4. Tell me about a conflict with a teammate.
5. Tell me about a time you worked on a team.
6. Tell me about a time you took initiative.
7. Tell me about a time you worked under pressure.
8. Tell me about a time you persuaded someone.
9. What's your biggest weakness?
10. Why this field?

8 stories, 10 questions. Mark each box where a story could answer the question. Every question needs at least two stories; no story should need to answer more than four.

Story map: 8 stories × 10 questions

STORY	LEADERSHIP	FAILURE	CONFLICT	TEAMWORK	INITIATIVE	PRESSURE	PERSUASION	WEAKNESS	WHY FIELD	TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF
Story 1: _____										
Story 2: _____										
Story 3: _____										
Story 4: _____										
Story 5: _____										
Story 6: _____										
Story 7: _____										
Story 8: _____										

From Tyler

Say your stories out loud and record them. A story you've only written isn't ready. The first time you say it, it'll run four minutes. Cut it to two.

Chapter 9 checklist

- [ ] All 25 self-questions answered.
- [ ] 8 stories written in the template.
- [ ] Story map filled in: every question has at least two stories.
- [ ] All 8 recorded, each under two minutes.

CHAPTER 10

"Why this industry, why this firm"

The 3 buckets and the worksheet.

"I'm passionate about finance" tells the interviewer nothing. Enthusiasm reads as real when it's specific, and it's specific when it comes from people you've actually talked to.

The 3-bucket "why"

#	BUCKET	WHAT GOES IN IT
1	Mentality	What about how you think or work fits this field? ("I like being measured against a clear number," "I like problems without an obvious answer.") Back it with a story.
2	2–3 specific things about the work	Real parts of the job you've learned about from calls, not from a website. ("Building a model from scratch and defending every assumption.")
3	The people and their standards	Who you've met and what stood out. ("Everyone I talked to at the firm described feedback the same way…") This is where your calls pay off.

EXAMPLE ONLY. A MADE-UP ANSWER SHOWING THE 3 BUCKETS.

"I've always liked work where you're measured against a clear number: I ran the register at a coffee shop and tracked our end-of-night counts to zero errors (mentality). From my calls this fall, what pulls me in is building a model from scratch and then having to defend every assumption to someone senior, and seeing a deal from the first pitch to close (the work). And every analyst I talked to at your firm described feedback the same way: direct, fast, and meant to make you better. That's the environment I want to start my career in (the people)."

The "why" worksheet

- [ ] Bucket 1, mentality: two traits you have that fit this work, each with a one-line story as proof.
- [ ] Bucket 2, the work: three specific tasks you'd do in the role. Where did you learn about each one? (Which call?)
- [ ] Bucket 3, the people: two people you've spoken with and one thing each said that stuck with you.
- [ ] Why this firm: one thing only this firm does, one person you've talked to there, and one reason it fits your bucket 1.
- [ ] Say it out loud in under 90 seconds. Record it. Cut anything a hundred other students could say.

Firm-specific answers come from your calls. The best "why us" quotes someone who works there. If you haven't talked to anyone at the firm yet, that's your next email.

Chapter 10 checklist

- [ ] All three buckets filled in, with a story for bucket 1.
- [ ] A firm-specific version for your top three firms.
- [ ] Recorded, under 90 seconds.

CHAPTER 11

Technicals by track

Study order and question lists for Finance and Accounting, plus Marketing and Tech.

Understand the concept first; the answer comes easier after that. For students starting recruiting, nobody expects you to know everything. They expect you to be learning, and to reason out loud when you don't know. Say answers out loud, work on paper, and use AI to close gaps, not to hand you answers.

Study order by field

FIELD	STUDY ORDER	HOW TO PRACTICE
Finance	Accounting (the three statements) → Valuation → Enterprise value vs. equity value → M&A → LBO	Say answers out loud, work on paper, and use AI to close gaps. If you can't explain it to a friend, you don't know it yet.
Marketing	The funnel (awareness to loyalty) → Metrics that matter → Brand teardown → Portfolio pieces → Campaign walkthrough	Build two things you can show: one campaign idea and one analysis. Talk about both without jargon.
Accounting	Debits and credits → The three statements and how they connect → Accruals and revenue recognition → Audit vs. tax vs. advisory → Why accounting, why this firm	Work each question on paper first, then explain it out loud. For every answer, say which statement it touches and why.
Tech (software, data, product)	One strong project you can explain end to end → Core data structures and problem solving → SQL → Product sense → Referral strategy	Practice explaining your thinking out loud as you solve. In tech, a referral often matters more than the application.

Finance questions

- [ ] Walk me through the three financial statements.
- [ ] How are the three statements connected?
- [ ] If depreciation goes up by $10, walk me through the three statements (assume a 25% tax rate).
- [ ] What's the difference between cash and accrual accounting?
- [ ] What is working capital, and why does it matter?
- [ ] What are the main ways to value a company?
- [ ] Walk me through a discounted cash flow (DCF) analysis.
- [ ] What is WACC and how do you calculate it?
- [ ] Why would you use comparable companies versus precedent transactions?
- [ ] What's the difference between enterprise value and equity value?

Marketing questions

- [ ] What's a brand you think does marketing well, and why?
- [ ] Tear down a recent campaign: goal, audience, channel, message, result.
- [ ] How would you market our product to college students?
- [ ] What's the difference between reach, engagement, and conversion?
- [ ] What is customer acquisition cost, and how would you lower it?
- [ ] How would you measure whether a campaign worked?
- [ ] Walk me through a piece in your portfolio.
- [ ] How would you grow a small business's Instagram from zero?
- [ ] If our email open rate dropped, what would you test first?
- [ ] How would you position a new product against a bigger competitor?

Accounting questions

- [ ] What's the difference between a debit and a credit?
- [ ] A company buys $1,000 of inventory with cash. What's the journal entry?
- [ ] Walk me through the three financial statements and how they connect.
- [ ] Depreciation goes up by $10. What happens on each statement? (Assume a 25% tax rate.)
- [ ] What is an accrual? Give an example of an accrued expense.
- [ ] A customer pays up front for a one-year subscription. When is the revenue recognized?
- [ ] What's the difference between accounts receivable and deferred revenue?
- [ ] What is the matching principle?
- [ ] What does an auditor actually do during fieldwork?
- [ ] What's the difference between audit, tax, and advisory?

Tech (software, data, product) questions

- [ ] Walk me through your best project: the problem, your role, the tech, and what you'd change.
- [ ] Reverse a string / find duplicates in a list. Talk through your approach first.
- [ ] When would you use a hash map instead of a list?
- [ ] What's the time complexity of your solution, and can you improve it?
- [ ] Write a SQL query to find the top 5 customers by total spend.
- [ ] What's the difference between an INNER JOIN and a LEFT JOIN?
- [ ] How would you find duplicate rows in a table?
- [ ] How would you improve an app you use every day?
- [ ] How would you measure whether a new feature is successful?
- [ ] Design a simple app for students to find study partners. What would you build first?

The full question bank for each track is a free download.

Chapter 11 checklist

- [ ] Pick your track's list and answer every question out loud once.
- [ ] Mark the ones you couldn't explain to a friend.
- [ ] Close one gap a day for two weeks.

CHAPTER 12

Interviews and superdays

The flow, recovering from a blank, and questions to ask.

An interview is the same skills you've been building, under a clock: your intro, your stories, your why, and your technicals. The difference is pressure, and the only fix for pressure is reps.

A typical 30-minute first round

PART	TIME	WHAT THEY'RE CHECKING
Small talk + tell me about yourself	3–5 min	The first two minutes set the tone. Energy up, answer under 90 seconds.
Behaviorals	8–12 min	Pull from your 8 stories. Situation, what you did, what changed, what you learned.
Why this field, why this firm	3–5 min	The 3 buckets, with names and details from your calls.
Technicals or case	8–15 min	Think out loud. Structure before answers.
Your questions	3–5 min	Two or three that show you did the work.

Recovering from a blank

1. Pause and say it: "Let me think about that for a second." Silence for five seconds is fine.
2. Say what you do know, then reason out loud toward the rest.
3. If it's a behavioral, pick the closest of your 8 stories and bridge: "The closest example I have is..."
4. If you're truly stuck: "I'm not sure, but here's how I'd find out," then come back to it later if you can.
5. Never bluff a technical answer. Interviewers can tell, and it costs more than "I don't know."

Questions to ask at the end

- What does a great intern do in the first two weeks that others don't?
- You mentioned [thing they said]. How did that come about?
- What's something about the team that's hard to see from the outside?
- What are you working on right now that you're most excited about?
- What do the strongest people on your team have in common?

Final rounds and superdays

- [ ] Keep your answers consistent across every interviewer; they compare notes.
- [ ] Eat, hydrate, and reset between rounds. Treat every interview as the first one.
- [ ] Research each interviewer: their path, their group, one thing to ask about.
- [ ] Send a short, specific thank-you to each interviewer the same day.
- [ ] Declining an offer: frame it as fit, not preference, and thank everyone who helped.

From Tyler

Do at least one mock with a stranger before a real interview. A friend grading you is kind. A stranger is closer to the real thing.

Chapter 12 checklist

- [ ] One full 30-minute mock, recorded and graded on the scorecard.
- [ ] A second mock with someone you don't know.
- [ ] Research on every interviewer before the day.
- [ ] Thank-you notes sent the same day.

CHAPTER 13

Externships and early experience

What counts, how to get it, and how to put it on a resume.

If you don't have an internship yet, the answer isn't to wait. It's to create real experience you can talk about. An externship is one of the fastest ways to do that.

An externship is a short, structured project that gives you real exposure to a field: a virtual project designed by a company, a job shadow, or a defined project for a small firm or startup. It's not a full internship, but it's real work you can put on a resume and talk about in an interview.

What counts

- [ ] Company-designed virtual externship projects with a real deliverable.
- [ ] A defined project for a local firm, a startup, or a professor, with a clear start, end, and output.
- [ ] Job shadowing that ends with something you produced (a memo, an analysis, a deck).

- Doesn't count: Watching videos and collecting a certificate with no deliverable.
- Doesn't count: "Helping out" with no defined task or result.

How to get one

1. Look for structured virtual externship programs that publish their projects and deliverables.
2. Ask on calls: "Is there ever a small project a student could help with?" (See the startup email template.)
3. Offer a scoped project: "I could put together a one-page competitor overview for your team in two weeks."
4. Finish it on time and send it with a short note. Then add it to your tracker and resume.

Putting it on your resume (EXAMPLE ONLY)

BEFORE	AFTER
Completed a virtual finance program.	Built a comparable-companies analysis of 6 consumer brands in a company-designed virtual externship; summarized findings in a 5-slide recommendation.

Chapter 13 checklist

- [ ] One externship or scoped project started this month.
- [ ] A clear deliverable and a deadline.
- [ ] Added to your resume with an outcome bullet when it's done.

CHAPTER 14

Your 8-week execution calendar

The weekly numbers, from zero to 500 emails.

This is the calendar we run in the program. Every week has a focus and a number. Hit the number, and the search takes care of itself far more often than you'd think.

From Week 2: 50 new sequenced emails, every follow-up due that week, and the tracker updated by Sunday night. 7 weeks × 50 = 350+.

8-week execution calendar

WEEK	FOCUS	EMAILS (CUMULATIVE)	CALLS
1	The game; resume passes the rubric; intro recorded; target list of 50 with contacts	0	0
2	AI outreach system live, first 50 sequenced emails	50	0
3	Cold email that gets answered; the call; thank-yous within 2 hours	150	3
4	The referral close on every call; 8 stories written and recorded	250	5
5	Why this industry, why this firm; 2 referrals or intros; technicals begin	300	5+
6	Technicals for your track; mock interview 1; apply to every open role on your list	350	5+
7	Mock interview 2 with a stranger; real first rounds	350+	5+
8	Results and the 6-month game plan	350+	5+

From Tyler

Two missed weeks in a row is where searches die. If you miss one, the next week's number doesn't go down. You make it up.

Every Sunday night

- [ ] Tracker updated.
- [ ] 50 new sequenced emails sent this week.
- [ ] Every follow-up due this week sent.
- [ ] Next week's calls and deadlines on the calendar.

CHAPTER 15

Your 6-month game plan

A template for the months after the 8 weeks.

The search doesn't end when the program does. Fill this in before your last session and review it on the first of every month.

6-month game plan

	MONTH 1	MONTH 2	MONTH 3	MONTH 4	MONTH 5	MONTH 6
Outreach target (new emails this month)						
Calls target						
Contacts to keep warm (names)						
Applications due this month (firm, role, deadline)						
Skill to build (and how)						
One thing to finish (project, externship, certification)						

Monthly review (first of every month)

- [ ] Did I hit my outreach and call numbers? If not, what got in the way?
- [ ] Who did I update this month? Who have I gone quiet on?
- [ ] What deadlines are coming in the next 60 days?
- [ ] What's the one thing that would make the biggest difference next month?

CHAPTER 16

What to do next

You now have everything I use. What's hard is doing it every week for 8 weeks: sending the 50 emails when nobody's replying yet, following up when it feels awkward, recording the story for the fourth time, and showing your numbers to someone who will tell you the truth about them.

That's what First Offer Academy is: a weekly 90-minute session, a weekly 60-minute 1:1, a pod of three, and a coach who reviews every piece of work and holds your student to a number. We don't promise offers; nobody honest can. We promise a fully executed search.

Want to run this with a coach every week?

First Offer Academy coaches business students starting recruiting until their first offer: Week 0 pre-work, a 12-week program (Weeks 1–8 core teaching, Weeks 9–12 mocks and networking), then weekly check-ins and mocks every other week until an offer. Founding cohort starts January 2027: 12 seats, everything included. Tuition and scholarship details are covered on the parent call.

Apply at firstofferacademy.com/apply

For parents: firstofferacademy.com/parents